Mahmud hadn't attempted to establish an empire in India. His Indian raids had mainly funded his Central Asian campaigns and turned Ghazni into a fine city, with a grand mosque and a library full of looted books.[12] After his death, the Ghaznavid raids ceased. Our knowledge of these raids comes entirely from Turko-Persian sources, including Alberuni. Curiously, writes Thapar, even for the worst of the raids, at Somnath Temple in 1025, local Hindu textual sources of the day neither mention it, nor suggest a sense of continuing social trauma.[13] If it were part of Hindu memory (as claimed by Hindu nationalists), it would have appeared recurringly. Instead, local textual sources suggest that socio-economic life bounced back and the raid was forgotten by the Indians.[14] Twelve years after the attack, a king from the Goa region recorded performing a pilgrimage to the temple, but he failed to mention Mahmud's raid.[15]

Thapar calls the 'unbroken silence' of the Hindu texts about Mahmud's raid on Somnath Temple 'an enigma'. Somnath was next to the major port of Veraval, and within two centuries, Persians and Arab merchants were actively trading with the local Hindu king. They were granted land to build a mosque in the vicinity of Somnath Temple and 'received assistance' from the temple priests.[16] Perhaps trading was more lucrative than preserving bad memories! Only after British scholars discovered the raids in the Turko-Persian sources in the nineteenth century—and used it to develop a narrative about Hindus and Muslims—was the social memory of the trauma 'reconstructed' by Hindu nationalists for their own purposes, writes Thapar.[17]

> Interestingly, the earliest claim that the raid resulted in something akin to a trauma for the Hindus was made not in India but in Britain, during a debate in the House of Commons in 1843, when members of the British parliament stated that Mahmud's attack on Somanatha had created painful feelings and had been hurtful to the Hindus for *nearly a thousand years*. Subsequent to this, references began to be made to the Hindu trauma. [emphasis mine]

Mahmud inflicted much suffering on the world, but he also accidentally paved the way for Alberuni to write his magnum opus. Alberuni's 'observations on Indian conditions, systems of knowledge, social norms and religion', writes Thapar, 'are probably the most incisive made by any visitor